



National University
Of Computer and Emerging Sciences

EVENTSYNC

AI-Assisted University Event Planning

Project Phase # 2:

Research Report — Product, Business & Market Evidence

Presented to

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In partial fulfillment

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Section C

Primary Research: Survey Overview

To validate Phase 1 assumptions, we conducted a primary research survey of 38 respondents involved in event coordination. The survey covered tool usage, coordination pain points, AI trust, and willingness to pay. This section presents the key findings and their implications for EVENTSYNC's product scope and target segment.

Survey Respondent Profile

A critical finding is that the respondent pool diverged from our intended target segment. 89% of respondents identified as university students, and 90% reported working within university or student organizations. Only 3 respondents were professional Event Managers, and 1 was from a marketing team. This segment mismatch is a significant research limitation that must be acknowledged — but it also reveals an important pivot signal, discussed in the Phase 2 Summary.

A limitation of this research is the relatively small sample size (38 respondents) and the heavy concentration of university students, which may limit the generalizability of results to professional event management organizations.

Profile Dimension	Finding
Total Responses	38 respondents
Primary Role	University Student: 74% Event Manager: 8% Student Organizer: 5%
Organization Type	University/student org: 90% Freelance planner: 3% Non-profit: 3%
Events Per Month	1–2 events: 92% 3–5 events: 8%
Team Size	4–7 people: 37% 8–15 people: 32% 15+ people: 18% 1–3 people: 13%

Segment Limitation: 90% of respondents are university/student organizers, not mid-sized event agency professionals (our Phase 1 primary segment). Findings confirm the core problem but suggest a segment pivot toward student & university organizers as the most accessible early adopter pool. See Phase 2 Summary for full implications.

Key Survey Statistics

Metric	Finding	Implication for EVENTSYNC
Current tool satisfaction	2.95 / 5	37% rated 3/5 and 29% rated 1-2/5. Majority are at best moderately satisfied — significant unmet need.
Last-minute disruptions	74% often/sometimes	Only 13% say disruptions are rare or never. Pre-event chaos is the norm, not the exception.
Current tools are fragmented	92% use WhatsApp	Teams rely on consumer messaging apps not built for coordination. EVENTSYNC's built-in chat replaces this with a purpose-built, structured alternative.
No dedicated PM tool	Only 8% use Trello/Asana/ClickUp	The market is almost entirely unaddressed by structured coordination tools.

Coordination time lost	50% spend 2–5 hrs/event	21% spend 6–10 hrs. Significant recoverable time that EVENTSYNC can reduce.
AI trust (with review)	87% open to AI	66% trust AI with human review, 21% fully. Only 3% flat reject AI — trust is achievable with right UX.
Willingness to pay	82% yes or maybe	Only 18% said No. Strong potential demand if value is demonstrated clearly.
Preferred pricing model	Pay-per-event: 63%	Monthly subscriptions preferred by only 18%. Per-event pricing aligns better with this segment's usage patterns.
Price sensitivity	74% want under \$20	21% accept \$20-50. Budget is tight but not zero — freemium or low-cost entry is key.

1. Product Research

Key Question: What exactly must this product do to solve the problem meaningfully?

1A. User Needs & Pain Points

Who Are the Users?

Our primary research reveals two overlapping user groups. The first, confirmed by this survey, is university and student event organizers — teams of 4–15 people managing 1–2 events per month using fragmented consumer tools like messaging apps, spreadsheets, and email. The second, supported by secondary research, is mid-sized professional event agencies managing recurring, multi-vendor events. Both groups share structurally identical coordination pain points despite differing in scale, budget, and organizational formality.

What Are They Trying to Achieve?

Users want to execute events without last-minute chaos, missed responsibilities, or communication breakdowns. Their core goals — confirmed both by survey responses and industry sources — are: ensuring task visibility across all team members, communicating changes instantly to the whole team, holding vendors and teammates accountable to deadlines, and reducing the personal stress that peaks in the final 1–2 weeks before an event.

Where Do They Struggle? (Primary + Secondary Evidence)

Survey data directly confirms all five pain points identified in Phase 1:

- Tasks get buried in chats and forgotten: Confirmed by 55% of survey respondents as a primary breakdown point. Qualitative responses described poster sizes getting lost in group messages the night before an event, a reward message being missed in a busy chat, and entire schedule changes going unread. A dedicated coordination channel — separate from general messaging — is needed to prevent critical information from disappearing in conversation noise.
- Unclear task ownership: 58% identified this as a major coordination failure point. Multiple respondents described situations where no one took responsibility for a task because the assignment was never formally recorded — it was only mentioned verbally or in a chat.

- Last-minute change communication failures: The single most common breakdown, cited by 68% of respondents. Venue changes, schedule reorders, and supply quantity errors were all mentioned as real examples — often discovered less than 24 hours before the event.
- Vendor and external party breakdowns: 32% cited vendor deadline misses. One respondent described a vendor who denied committing to skilled labor because no written record existed — a direct consequence of informal, unstructured coordination with no audit trail. A built-in chat system with task linkage and message history would create the accountability record that informal tools cannot.
- Miscommunication as root cause: When asked to name the single most common execution problem, the overwhelming majority of open-ended responses converged on one word: miscommunication. Respondents elaborated on information overload in group chats, lack of read receipts for critical updates, and no single source of truth.

Primary Research Validation: All five core pain points from Phase 1 are confirmed by survey data. The problem is real, frequent, and felt with emotional intensity across both student and professional event coordinators.

1B. Existing Solutions & Substitutes

Survey data reveals the actual tool landscape used by our respondents — which is far more informal than Phase 1's secondary research assumed:

Tool / Approach	Survey Data + What It Does Well / Where It Fails
Messaging Apps (WhatsApp etc.)	Used by 92% of respondents. Universal and friction-free, but creates the core problem: critical messages get buried, there are no read confirmations for task assignments, and change notifications reach people unreliably. EVENTSYNC's built-in chat is designed specifically to solve these gaps.
Google Sheets	Used by 63%. Good for structured data but requires manual updates, no notification logic, and quickly becomes outdated when plans change rapidly.
Email	Used by 55%. More formal but too slow for real-time event coordination; not monitored consistently during execution windows.
Phone Calls	Used by 55%. Used as an escalation channel when messaging fails — a clear signal that the primary communication tools break down under pressure.
Trello / Asana / ClickUp	Used by only 8%. Structured and feature-rich but have not penetrated this segment, likely due to onboarding friction and perceived complexity for short-horizon, small-team events.

Key Gap Confirmed: Not a single respondent reported using a dedicated event coordination or AI-powered tool. The entire market is operating on improvised combinations of consumer messaging apps and manual spreadsheets. This represents a near-zero competition environment at the grassroots segment level.

1C. Product Scope & Differentiation

What EVENTSYNC Must Do (Survey-Validated)

Survey responses — both quantitative and qualitative — converged on five capabilities that respondents repeatedly wished existed:

- Automatic reminders for assigned tasks: Multiple respondents independently requested automated nudges for team members. 'There should be a feature which understands each member's responsibility and sends automatic reminders' — Survey Respondent.
- Single source of truth for updates: The most requested qualitative feature was a system that instantly notifies everyone when plans change, including who specifically is affected. 'If something changes from X to Y, it should instantly update everyone.'
- A built-in team chat where all coordination happens in one place: Since 92% of coordination currently happens in consumer messaging apps that bury critical information, EVENTSYNC's own chat system brings that conversation into a structured environment where tasks, deadlines, and responsibilities are directly linked to messages — nothing can be buried or forgotten.
- Clear role and responsibility visibility: 58% cited role ambiguity as a breakdown point. A dashboard showing each person's tasks, deadlines, and completion status was the most-requested visual feature.
- AI with human confirmation: 66% of respondents want AI assistance but only with human review. The product must surface AI suggestions, not silently automate decisions.

What EVENTSYNC Will NOT Attempt in MVP

- Attendee-facing registration or ticketing (Eventbrite's domain — not our differentiation).
- Budget accounting or financial reconciliation (deferred to later iteration).
- Post-event analytics beyond basic execution scoring.
- GPS tracking or attendance monitoring (mentioned once in survey — niche request).
- Full vendor contract management — out of MVP scope.

How Is It Meaningfully Different?

EVENTSYNC does not compete directly with messaging apps — it replaces the coordination function they were never designed to perform. By building its own team chat natively into the coordination platform, EVENTSYNC ensures that every message exists in an environment where tasks can be extracted, assigned, deadline-linked, and tracked — without relying on third-party integrations or external data access. The differentiation is purposeful design: a communication layer built for event execution, not borrowed from a general-purpose consumer tool.

2. Business Research

Key Question: Why could this exist as a sustainable product or business?

2A. Customer & Buyer Dynamics

Survey data introduces an important revision to our Phase 1 buyer model. Our respondents are not professional agency owners with software budgets — they are university students, society presidents, and volunteer organizers. The buyer and user are the same person, and discretionary spending is extremely limited.

However, this does not eliminate business viability — it reframes it. Two paths emerge from the survey data:

- Direct-to-student (freemium or pay-per-event): 63% prefer pay-per-event pricing. A free tier covering 1–2 events per month with a low per-event fee for additional events matches this segment's usage pattern and budget constraints precisely.

- Institution licensing: Respondents operate within universities. If EVENTSYNC demonstrates value at the student level, a licensing deal with student affairs offices or societies federations becomes a viable B2B path — shifting the buyer from individual students to university administrations with actual software budgets.

Assumption (Now Partially Revised): Our Phase 1 assumption that mid-sized agencies are the primary buyer remains valid for secondary research but is not confirmed by primary research. The confirmed early adopter is the university/student organizer segment. Agency buyers require a separate validation track.

2B. Revenue & Cost Logic

Willingness to Pay — Survey Evidence

82% of respondents said 'Yes' or 'Maybe' to paying for an event coordination tool. Only 18% declined. This is a strong signal of latent demand. However, price sensitivity is high: 74% expect to pay under \$20/month, and 21% accept \$20–50.

The preferred model is pay-per-event (63%), not monthly subscription (18%). This fundamentally changes the pricing strategy from Phase 1's subscription-first assumption. A per-event model with a low base price (e.g., \$3–8 per event) is better aligned with how this segment thinks about software spending — as a direct cost tied to a specific project, not an ongoing overhead.

Cost Structure Implications

- AI infrastructure: Natural Language Processing (NLP) based task extraction from EVENTSYNC chat messages is the core compute cost driver. Per-event pricing must cover inference costs per coordination cycle.
- Cloud hosting: Hosting the built-in chat system and all event coordination data adds recurring infrastructure cost — but keeps all data within EVENTSYNC's own environment, eliminating third-party data dependency.
- Engineering: The MVP requires building both the coordination chat interface and the AI task extraction layer — a more complex but self-contained technical scope compared to third-party integrations.
- Acquisition cost is near-zero for this segment: Student-to-student referral and campus society networks are natural viral distribution channels.

2C. Business Risks & Constraints

- Willingness to pay is conditional: The 61% 'Maybe' group will only convert if value is demonstrated within the first event cycle. If EVENTSYNC fails to show clear time savings or reduced chaos during the first use, they will not return.
- AI trust must be earned: 66% want human review before AI actions are committed. Removing human confirmation in pursuit of automation speed would be a fatal UX mistake. Trust builds through accuracy and transparency — not speed.
- Data privacy concerns are real and personal: Multiple survey respondents explicitly mentioned data security as a precondition for trust. One respondent stated they would only trust a local LLM where their data stays on-device. Because EVENTSYNC hosts its own chat system, all coordination data remains within the platform — a significant privacy advantage over approaches that require scanning third-party messaging apps. However, secure storage, transparent data policies, and clear retention controls must still be built from day one.
- Revenue model misalignment risk: A per-event model generates episodic revenue rather than predictable MRR. This makes growth forecasting harder and reduces the product's attractiveness to investors who prefer subscription metrics.

- Segment ceiling: University students manage 1–2 events per month. Even at 100% conversion, per-student revenue is low. Scaling requires either volume (many students) or segment graduation (moving converted users into professional agency customers as they grow in their careers).

3. Market & Industry Research

Key Question: Why does this problem matter in the broader market, and why now?

3A. Market Context

Target Market Definition — Revised

Phase 1 defined the primary target as mid-sized event agencies. Primary research reveals the most immediately addressable market is student and university event organizers — a high-volume, underserved, and tool-naïve segment. Secondary research confirms that the broader professional event management software market remains a valid medium-term target once product-market fit is established at the grassroots level.

Market Size

The global event management software market was valued between \$8 billion and \$15 billion in 2024, with consistent double-digit CAGR projections through 2030 (Grand View Research; MarketsandMarkets, 2024). The student/university organizer segment is not captured in these figures — it represents an informal, pre-commercial market that existing platforms have not addressed. This is a bottom-of-pyramid opportunity: low revenue per user but high volume, low competition, and high brand loyalty potential if captured early.

Why Now? Relevant Industry Trends

- Consumer messaging tools are failing as coordination tools: 92% of respondents use general messaging apps for event coordination — yet 68% cite last-minute change communication as their top breakdown point and 55% say tasks get buried in chats. The evidence confirms that consumer messaging apps are not coordination tools. EVENTSYNC's purpose-built chat closes this gap by design rather than by integration.
- AI adoption is already normalized among this segment: 66% of respondents have already used AI tools (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Notion AI). The population is AI-literate and AI-comfortable, removing the educational barrier to adoption.
- No existing tool owns this segment: Only 8% of respondents use any structured project management tool. The grassroots event coordination space is essentially uncontested by structured software.
- Event management software market is growing: AI integration is becoming expected, with Bizzabo earning Gartner Leader status in June 2025. The competitive pressure is at the enterprise tier — leaving the student and SME tier wide open.

3B. Competitive Landscape

Direct Competitors

Cvent (acquired by Blackstone for \$4.6 billion in 2024), Bizzabo, and Eventbrite dominate the professional event management space. These platforms focus on attendee registration, venue management, and marketing — not internal team coordination and execution risk detection. They are priced and positioned entirely out of reach for the student segment.

Indirect Competitors (Project Management Tools)

Asana, Trello, Monday.com, and ClickUp are the most commonly used substitutes in the professional segment. Survey data reveals they have achieved near-zero penetration in the student segment (8% usage). Their failure to capture this market is attributable to high onboarding friction, feature complexity, and a pricing model built for teams with software budgets — not university societies.

Non-Consumption — The Dominant Reality

The majority of our survey respondents are non-consumers of any coordination software. They rely on consumer messaging apps because they are free, familiar, and already where their team communicates. EVENTSYNC does not need to displace a competitor — it needs to create a category for structured coordination in a segment that has never used one. By building its own purpose-built chat into the platform, EVENTSYNC offers a familiar communication experience while eliminating the coordination failures that general messaging tools produce. This is a significantly more favorable competitive position than Phase 1 assumed.

3C. Structural Barriers

- Behavioral inertia around existing messaging habits: Teams currently coordinate entirely through consumer messaging apps. Switching to a new dedicated tool requires behavioral change and buy-in from all team members — not just the organizer. EVENTSYNC must demonstrate value quickly in the first event cycle and provide a familiar chat-like interface to lower the transition friction.
- Privacy and data concerns: Survey respondents raised data privacy organically and without prompting. Because EVENTSYNC hosts its own chat system — rather than scanning third-party apps — it avoids the most sensitive privacy concerns. However, secure storage, transparent data policies, and clear user control over coordination data must be built and communicated clearly from launch.
- Freemium conversion friction: Students in the 'Maybe' category (61%) will not pay without experiencing clear value first. A generous free tier is necessary to build the habit and prove value before a payment request is made.

4. Economic Research — Macro Risks

Key Question: Why does this problem matter economically, and what macro risks apply?

4A. Macroeconomic Environment

The global SaaS sector saw revenue growth decline to 12% in 2024, down from over 21% in prior years, with enterprise-sized firms seeing growth fall to 10% (BDO, 2025). Inflation and elevated interest rates have increased scrutiny of software spending. However, US tech spending is forecast to reach \$2.7 trillion in 2025 (Forrester, 2025), and 87% of startup founders reported improved confidence in their financial prospects in 2025 (Mercury, 2025). For a student-segment product with near-zero customer acquisition

costs and low infrastructure overhead, macro SaaS headwinds are less severe than they would be for an enterprise-focused product.

4B. Macro Risk Factors

Risk Factor	Impact on EVENTSYNC
SaaS spending consolidation	Enterprises are cutting underused tools. Less relevant for the student segment where there is no existing budget to consolidate. Risk increases when targeting professional agencies.
Interest rate environment	Raises cost of startup capital. Discipline in unit economics is critical. Per-event pricing with low infrastructure costs is more resilient than subscription models requiring high upfront investment.
AI commoditization risk	By 2026, AI alone will not differentiate products (SaaS Trends, 2025). EVENTSYNC must build event-domain intelligence and a network effect from accumulated coordination data that generic AI platforms cannot replicate quickly.
Data privacy regulations	75% of consumers will not purchase from organizations they do not trust with their data (Cisco, 2024). GDPR, CCPA, and new US state laws apply to any platform storing team communication data. EVENTSYNC's own chat system keeps data in-platform — a privacy architecture advantage — but secure storage and transparent policies are still legally required.
Student purchasing power	University students have limited discretionary income. Macro inflation reduces spending capacity further. Per-event pricing under \$10 and a strong free tier are necessary responses.

4C. Favorable Macro Signals

- AI literacy is high in the target segment: 66% of survey respondents already use AI tools regularly. The adoption education barrier — historically a major cost for AI products — does not exist for this cohort.
- Event industry resilience: Despite inflation, event budgets are increasing. The event management software market is growing at 13–17% CAGR through 2030, sustaining long-term opportunity even if early-stage traction is at the student level.
- Zero-cost distribution channel: Campus networks, student societies, and word-of-mouth referrals are free distribution channels with high conversion density. EVENTSYNC can grow within universities without paid acquisition.

5. Assumptions & Evidence Tracker

CONFIRMED ASSUMPTIONS
Coordination failures are driven by miscommunication and task burial in chat. EVIDENCE: 68% of respondents cited last-minute change communication as a breakdown point; 55% cited buried tasks. Qualitative responses provided vivid real-world examples confirming this as the core operational failure.

Consumer messaging apps dominate coordination but are structurally inadequate. EVIDENCE: 92% of respondents use general messaging apps for coordination, yet 68% cite last-minute change communication as their top failure point. This validates EVENTSYNC's decision to build a dedicated coordination chat rather than rely on third-party integrations.

Existing tools (Asana, Trello, ClickUp) have not penetrated the grassroots event segment. EVIDENCE: Only 8% of respondents use any structured PM tool. The segment is effectively uncontested.

AI with human review is the correct trust model for this audience. EVIDENCE: 87% are open to AI assistance; 66% require human review. Full automation is not acceptable to the majority — human-in-the-loop is the correct design choice.

Willingness to pay exists but is price-sensitive. EVIDENCE: 82% said Yes or Maybe to paying. 74% expect under \$20. Per-event pricing is preferred by 63% over monthly subscriptions.

REVISED ASSUMPTIONS

Primary early adopter segment: REVISED from 'mid-sized event agencies' to 'university and student event organizers.' Primary research shows this is the most immediately accessible, highest-pain, zero-competition segment. Agency validation requires a separate research track.

Pricing model: REVISED from 'tiered monthly subscription per agency' to 'pay-per-event with a free tier.' Monthly subscription is preferred by only 18% of respondents. Per-event pricing at under \$20 matches actual behavior and willingness to pay of the confirmed segment.

Segment scale: REVISED. University organizers manage 1–2 events per month. Revenue per user is lower than the agency model assumed. Volume and institution licensing (university administration) must compensate.

HIGH-RISK ASSUMPTIONS

Data privacy concerns will not block adoption: Survey respondents raised privacy concerns unprompted. One explicitly stated they would only trust a local LLM. Because EVENTSYNC uses its own chat system rather than scanning third-party apps, the most sensitive privacy risk is avoided. However, users still need assurance about how their coordination data is stored, who can access it, and how long it is retained.

The 'Maybe' WTP group (61%) will convert after experiencing value: Conditional willingness to pay requires the product to deliver clear, measurable improvement within the first event. If the MVP does not immediately demonstrate value, this group will not convert to paying users.

Mid-sized event agencies are a valid medium-term segment: Secondary research supports this, but it has not been validated by primary research. Agency buyer dynamics, procurement cycles, and willingness to pay at professional pricing levels remain unconfirmed.

Institution licensing is viable: The hypothesis that universities will pay for organization-wide EVENTSYNC access is untested. It requires a separate research and sales track targeting student affairs offices.

6. Phase 2 Summary

What Assumptions Were Confirmed?

Primary research confirms the core problem with high fidelity. Event coordination failures — driven by buried messages in group chats, unclear task ownership, and last-minute change communication breakdowns — are real, frequent, and felt with emotional intensity across both student and professional event organizers. The tool landscape at the grassroots level is almost entirely consumer messaging apps and spreadsheets, with no structured coordination tool present. AI assistance with human review is trusted and desired. 82% of respondents show some willingness to pay. The problem, the tool gap, and the appetite for a solution are all validated. Critically, EVENTSYNC's decision to build its own chat system rather than integrate with third-party messaging apps is supported by the evidence: users need a purpose-built coordination environment, not a patch on top of a general messaging tool.

What Assumptions Remain High-Risk?

Three risks remain unresolved. First, data privacy: even with EVENTSYNC's own chat system eliminating third-party data scanning, users still need assurance about how their coordination data is stored and retained — consent architecture must be designed before any MVP launch. Second, conversion from 'Maybe' to paying: 61% of respondents gave a conditional answer that depends entirely on experiencing clear value in their first event cycle. Third, the mid-sized agency segment remains unvalidated by primary research — it is a secondary research assumption that requires its own validation track before Phase 3 scope is extended to that segment.

How Has Product Scope Changed?

Phase 1 proposed a broad platform for mid-sized event agencies. Primary research narrows and refocuses this significantly. The confirmed early adopter is the university/student event organizer — an AI-literate, price-sensitive user managing small teams across 1–2 events per month using fragmented consumer tools. The product scope narrows to: a built-in coordination chat where AI automatically extracts tasks from conversations, simple role-linked task visibility, automatic reminders for assigned tasks, and a human-review confirmation layer before any AI action is committed. All enterprise features, vendor CRM, post-event analytics, and external app integrations are deferred.

What Will the MVP in Phase 3 Focus On and Exclude?

MVP Focus

- A built-in team chat system where all event coordination conversations happen — purpose-built so that messages, tasks, and deadlines exist in the same structured environment.
- AI-powered task extraction from chat conversations within EVENTSYNC — automatically identifying tasks, deadlines, and responsible persons from coordination messages sent inside the platform.
- A simple dashboard showing each team member's assigned tasks, deadlines, and completion status in real time.
- Automated reminders sent to individuals for their specific tasks — the single most-requested feature across qualitative survey responses.
- A human confirmation step before any AI-extracted task is formally assigned — non-negotiable based on trust data showing 66% require human review.
- Transparent privacy controls and clear data retention policies for all coordination data stored within the platform.

- Pay-per-event or free tier pricing model — aligned with the confirmed segment's willingness to pay and usage pattern.

MVP Exclusions

- Mid-sized agency features (vendor contract management, multi-stakeholder dashboards, enterprise compliance).
- Attendee registration, ticketing, or event marketing functionality.
- Budget tracking and financial reconciliation.
- Integration with external messaging apps (WhatsApp, email, Slack — deferred to Phase 4+ if validated by demand).
- Post-event analytics and reporting beyond a basic execution summary.

The MVP's single testable hypothesis: University and student event organizers using EVENTSYNC's built-in chat and AI-powered task extraction system will experience measurably fewer missed tasks and last-minute coordination failures — and at least 30% of free-tier users will convert to a paid per-event model within their second event cycle.

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